
**Unit 1, Option C,
Topic C7: Retreat
from Empire:
Decolonisation in
Africa, c1957-81**

The focus of this topic is on the remarkably quick British withdrawal from Empire in Africa in the latter part of the 20th century. Since the focus of this unit is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will however be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of the specification offer a framework for understanding the themes of the exercise of imperial power and the challenges to and loss of that power. The bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, a question on the orderly transfer of power could range over bullet points 2, 3 and 4.

The first bullet point relates to Britain's assessment of its imperial position in the 'aftermath of Suez'. Although there will be no specific questions on the period before 1957, students should be aware of the damaging impact of the Second World War on both the British economy and Britain's standing as a world power and her inability to compete with the super-powers of the USSR and the USA. They should be aware of the impact of the Suez Crisis in exposing British weakness and Macmillan's desire to recapture US benevolence, partly by distancing Britain from an imperial past. They should be aware of Macmillan's audit of Empire in 1957 and the unwillingness of the new government to face any prolonged military conflict to maintain imperial power in the light of economic weakness and changing attitudes amongst the public to Empire and its value.

The second bullet point relates to the African dimension and the attitude to British imperial power amongst the African elites and the growth of independence movements as a consequence in the 1950s and 1960s. Students should understand and be able to exemplify the reasons for and the pace and pattern of independence, from Ghana in 1957 to the Gambia in 1965, by which time most of the imperial possessions had become independent states.

The third bullet point relates to the immediate aftermath of the granting of independence in east and west Africa and students should understand something of the tensions and violence that developed in certain ex-imperial possessions, such as Uganda in the 1970s and most importantly in Nigeria in the 1960s. Questions will not be set which focus specifically and exclusively on particular countries but students should be prepared to provide exemplification in more general questions on the orderly or disorderly nature of decolonisation and its immediate consequences.

The fourth bullet point relates to the rather special circumstances in southern Africa and includes both Britain's troubled relationship with the Union of South Africa and the exceptional difficulties involved in Southern Rhodesia. Students should understand why these two countries posed such problems and in particular why Zimbabwe did not gain recognised independence until 1980.